ADVERTISEMENT

Glossary of Naval Skills Terms

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Aids to navigation—lighthouses, navigation lights, buoys, and beacons especially constructed to assist in the safe navigation of vessels.

almanac (celestial navigation)—a periodic publication of variable astronomical information.

anchorage—an area assigned for vessels to anchor or tie up to a mooring buoy.

armament—weapons of a ship or aircraft.

armor belts—thick steel belts on the sides of olden day capital ships' hulls to give protection against shells and torpedoes.

athwartships—crosswise direction on a vessel.

atomic time—time reckoned by the use of an atomic clock, usually cesium-based. See also Coordinated Universal Time.

barge—in the case of boats, any small craft used for transporting officers senior to a ship's captain; in cargo hauling, a long, large craft, usually flat-bottomed, unpowered, and towed by other craft, used for transporting raw materials, freight, or liquids.

battle dressing station—first aid station equipped to handle battle casualties.

beacon—a navigation aid consisting of a tower or pile normally fitted with a daymark (i.e., a daybeacon), and sometimes also with a light, used in lieu of buoys to guide vessels through navigable waterways.

beam—extreme width of a ship or boat.

bearing—direction of an object from an observer, measured clockwise from one of three reference directions: true north, magnetic north, or a vessel's bow.

bend (knot)—a kind of knot used to join two lines together.

berthing compartment—living quarters for the enlisted crew on a Navy ship.

bilges—spaces between the inner and outer bottoms of a ship.

bitts—a type of deck fitting consisting of a pair of vertical stubby heavy metal cylinders used for handling and securing mooring lines.

boat etiquette—the naval customs and traditions pertaining to small boats.

boat officer—embarked junior officer in charge of a small boat under certain circumstances.

bollard—a large, cylindrical wooden or iron fitting on a pier, often toe-shaped, used in securing a ship's mooring lines.

bowsprit—a beam that extends from the bow of a boat that supports a platform called a pulpit above it.

breast line—a mooring line that is perpendicular to a pier and a vessel, used to control a vessel's distance from the pier.

bridge—a platform or compartment on the upper superstructure of a ship, submarine, or large boat from which maneuvers are directed when underway.

building dock—a dry dock used for ship construction.

building ways—an open construction area in a shipyard fitted with blocks upon which ships are built.

bulkheads—inner walls of a vessel or naval installation on land.

buoy—a moored floating marker placed to guide vessels safely along navigable waterways.

camel—a long, low, and narrow floating wooden platform sometimes placed between a ship and a pier or between ships when mooring to act as a buffer or to do maintenance.

capstan—a rotating drum of a winch that raises an anchor cable or other heavy weight.

CAPTOR mine—a mine consisting of an encapsulated homing torpedo suspended above the sea bottom, activated by the acoustic or magnetic signature of a passing ship or submarine.

cardinal buoyage system—a standardized international buoyage system used mainly in foreign offshore waters to mark the position of a hazard or direction of safe water.

cardinal compass points—north, south, east, and west.

cartographers—map and chart makers.

catamaran—a twin-hulled vessel.

CBDR—a constant bearing, decreasing range approach situation.

CBR warfare—chemical, biological, or nuclear (radiological) warfare.

CCS—central control station, a main damage control and coordination center within a ship's damage control organization on newer ships.

chain locker—a compartment in which a vessel's anchor chain is stowed.

chain pipe—a heavily constructed pipe through which an anchor chain runs from a vessel's deck down to the chain locker.

chain stopper—a short length of chain fitted with a turnbuckle and pelican hook to clamp and hold an anchor chain in place.

chartplotters—electronic navigational plotters that project a vessel's navigational plot on regulation electronic navigational charts.

chock—a metal fitting on board a ship through which mooring lines are passed.

class (of ships)—a number of ships or submarines built to the same design and bearing the name of the first ship built in it.

cleat—an anvil-shaped deck fitting for securing lines on a boat, ship, or pier.

closest point of approach (CPA)—the distance and bearing from a reference ship to a maneuvering ship at the point where they make the closest approach to each other.

COLREGS—abbreviation for International Regulations for the Prevention of Collisions at Sea, 1972, the international rules of the road convention governing how vessels are to be maneuvered in international waters of the highseas.

commissioning—the formal placement of an officer or naval vessel on active government service

compass rose—a graphic on a nautical chart depicting a true bearing circle with a magnetic bearing circle within it, offset by the variation angle at the location depicted, with a caption in the center giving the size of the variation angle and its annual rate of change.

ConRep—connected replenishment of a ship at sea from another ship alongside.

controllable-pitch propeller—a ship propeller capable of varying the pitch of its blades.

Coordinated Universal Time (UTC)—atomic time based on vibrations of the cesium atom designated as the world timekeeping standard on 1 January 1972.

course—the true or magnetic direction that a vessel is steered through the water.

coxswain—a person in charge of a small powerboat or rowing shell.

damage control—measures used to limit damage to a ship from enemy action, fire, flooding, and smoke.

damage control assistant (DCA)—the officer on board a ship charged with running the damage control organization.

date/time group—a standardized format wherein military and other government messages are referenced and filed by the originator and the date and UTC time of origination.

daybeacon—an unlighted structural aid to navigation.

daylight saving time—standard zone time set ahead one hour to extend the time of daylight in the evening, usually in summer months except in certain European countries where it may be adopted in wintertime.

daymark—a triangular or square marker affixed to a beacon to indicate its purpose, and on cardinal buoys, a conical top-mark that indicates the direction of danger.

day shapes—geometric shapes such as balls, cones, and diamonds usually made of canvas stretched over metal frameworks displayed by vessels engaged in certain activities or in a special status.

DCC—damage control central, a main damage control and coordination center within the damage control organization on older ships.

DCPO—damage control petty officer; one is normally assigned to each division on Navy ships.

dead reckoning—a method of deducing the position of an air, land, or water craft by using the courses and speeds traveled since the last established position or fix.

depth contours—hydrographic lines on a nautical chart delineating the limits of areas of certain depths and shoal waters.

depth finder—another name for an echo sounder. See echo sounder.

designation (ship)—a group of letters and hull numbers that identify a ship.

deviation—deflection angle between magnetic north and the north point of a magnetic compass needle caused by the presence of iron metal.

dividers—instrument for measuring distance on a nautical chart.

dogs (ship)—latches around the perimeter of doors and hatches of a ship that fasten them in place when shut.

draft—depth to which the hull of a vessel sinks beneath the waterline, measured vertically.

dry dock—a shipyard structure able to contain a ship and be drained or raised so as to leave the ship high and dry.

ECDIS—acronym for electronic chart display and information system, a type of GPS plotter accepted as a legal alternative to manual position plots on paper charts.

echo sounder—a sonic device used to obtain water depths by measuring the time required for a sound pulse to make a round trip to the sea bottom and back.

ECN—a standardized electronic navigational chart that meets technical requirements of the IMO for use with ECDIS chartplotters.

ECS—electronic chart systems plotter not certified to be used in lieu of a navigational plot maintained on regulation electronic navigational charts or on paper nautical charts.

eductor—a jet-type dewatering pump.

endurance—the maximum time or distance a vessel can cruise at its most economical speed.

equation of time—the difference between apparent time as reckoned by the passage of the actual Sun and mean time reckoned by the mean Sun.

fantail—the after part of the main deck of a vessel.

fathometer—alternative name for a depth finder. See also echo sounder.

fender—pneumatic rubber cylinder with line attached placed on the side of a ship or boat to act as a buffer between it and a pier or another vessel.

fid—a pointed, round, tapered wooden tool used for splicing fiber lines.

fix—a position determined by the intersection of two or more simultaneous lines of position.

fog signals—audible signals consisting of whistles or bells required by the nautical rules of the road whenever a vessel is either under way, moored to a buoy, or anchored in reduced visibility conditions.

forecastle—forward part of the main deck of a vessel.

foremast—forward-most mast of a ship having more than one mast.

frame (ship construction)—transverse girders running athwartships from a ship's keel.

freeboard—the distance from the waterline to the main deck of a ship's hull.

galley—the kitchen on a vessel.

gig—a ship's boat designated for use by the commanding officer.

give-way vessel—the vessel obliged under the nautical rules of the road to maneuver to avoid another vessel during an approach situation while under way. See also stand-on vessel.

gnomonic projection—a chart projection in which the globe is projected outward onto a plane tangent to the globe in the center of the area depicted. Great circles appear as straight lines on this type of chart.

GPS—the U.S. Global Positioning System that uses a system of thirty-one operational orbiting satellites to provide three-dimensional positioning information everywhere on the Earth accurate to within fifteen meters or less.

graving dock—another name for an excavated dry dock in which vessel maintenance is performed.

great circle—any circle formed by the intersection of a plane passing through the Earth's center with the Earth's surface; represents the shortest distance between two points on the globe.

Greenwich Mean Time (GMT)—time based on the relationship of the mean Sun to the prime meridian passing through Greenwich, England.

ground tackle—any equipment having to do with a ship's anchors, anchor cable, or handling gear.

GTE—gas turbine engine.

gunwale—the intersection of the main deck of a ship with its side plating.

gyrocompass—an electromechanical compass aligned with true north by means of a spinning gyroscope.

gyrocompass repeater—a remote gyroscope readout duplicating a vessel's gyrocompass card.

habitability—the features designed into a vessel to provide comfortable living conditions for the crew.

hatch—a horizontal opening in the deck of a ship or boat.

hawsepipe—the large, heavily constructed pipe in a ship or boat hull through which the anchor cable chain runs on its way from the deck to the water.

hawser—a thick line used for towing or high-line transfer.

head—nautical term for a lavatory on a vessel; a vessel's bow.

heading—the true or magnetic direction in which a vessel is facing at any moment.

helm—the steering gear for a vessel.

hitch (knot)—a kind of knot used to fasten a line to or around an object.

hold (of ships)—a large storage space below deck on a merchant ship.

hourglass—a timepiece consisting of two glass chambers joined by a narrow opening through which fine sand runs from one the top chamber to the bottom one, traditionally every thirty minutes.

hull—the body or shell of a ship or seaplane.

hydrographic information—information on a nautical chart pertaining to water features such as depth, depth contours, bottom composition, and channels.

hyperbolic navigation systems—twentieth-century radio navigation systems that formed a hyperbolic pattern of LOPs within their areas of coverage by means of time differences between signals broadcast from two or more transmitting stations.

IED—improvised explosive device such as a remote-controlled bomb.

IET—in-port emergency team, a first-response in-port damage control team.

IMO—International Maritime Organization; a specialized agency of the United Nations responsible for setting standards for the safety, security, and environmental performance of international shipping.

in extremis—an approach situation under the nautical rules of the road in which there is imminent danger of collision.

inland rules—the set of national rules governing how vessels are to be maneuvered in U.S. inland waters.

in-port emergency team (IET)—a first-response in-port damage control team.

International Date Line—the 180th meridian in the mid-Pacific region along which it is one day later to the west of the line than it is to the east.

Intracoastal Waterway—the extended inland channel of navigable waterways in which a light-draft vessel can navigate along the U.S. East and Gulf Coasts from the Chesapeake Bay almost to the Mexican border without going into the ocean.

jackstaff—a small vertical flagpole at the bow of a Navy ship from which the First Navy Jack is flown when at anchor.

Jacob's ladder—a portable ladder made of rope used to climb up the side of a ship.

keel—the central longitudinal girder of a ship from which the frames and hull plating rise.

knot—a nautical speed unit equivalent to one nautical mile (two thousand yards) per hour; a fastening in a rope or line.

landlubber—a person who knows nothing of the sea.

lateral buoyage system—a standardized system of buoyage used to mark inland waterways.

latitude—the angular distance of a position on the Earth's surface measured from the equator northward or southward through 90°.

leap second—a periodic one-second correction applied to bring UTC and GMT into conformance with each other.

line of position (LOP)—a locus of points along which a position must be located.

list (of ship)—a permanent lean of a ship to port or starboard.

LNB—large navigational buoy.

longitude—the angular distance of a position on the Earth's surface measured from the prime meridian eastward or westward through 180°.

loran—an electronic radio navigation system used extensively in the twentieth century in which the time difference between the reception of pulse signals originated at a master and one or more secondary radio stations was used to form hyperbolic grid lines of position. The intersection of two such lines formed a fix.

magnetic compass—a mechanical compass aligned with the magnetic north pole by means of a magnetized compass needle.

main deck—the top deck of a ship's hull.

mainmast—the second mast of a ship with two or more masts, except when the first is taller.

maneuverability—the way a ship or submarine handles in turns, backing down, stopping, or evading enemy weapons; and for a submarine, diving and surfacing.

maneuvering board—a printed sheet used in solving relative motion problems.

marlinspike—a tapered steel or wooden tool used for separating strands of rope.

marlinspike seamanship—skill with rope, line, and other deck gear.

material readiness conditions—three basic states of watertight integrity set on Navy ships, consisting of conditions X-RAY, YOKE, and ZEBRA.

mean time—time based on the relationship of the mean Sun with the Earth; that is, a make-believe Sun that travels around the Earth at the equator at a constant speed of 15° per hour.

Med moor—a type of mooring common to the Mediterranean Sea region in which a vessel is secured at a right angle to the pier.

mercator projection—the best known and most widely used projection for maps and nautical charts, on which rhumb lines appear as straight lines.

mess deck—dining compartment for the enlisted crew on a Navy ship.

mizzen mast—a third mast aft of the mainmast on a large sailing ship.

motor sailer—a type of boat designed to be propelled by both power and sail at the same time.

nautical mile—a distance of 6,076 feet, about one and one-seventh times a land mile.

navigation—the art and science of directing a vessel or aircraft from one position to another.

navigation markers—buoys and beacons marking a navigable waterway.

NAVSAT—name given to an early satellite-based global positioning system launched and maintained by the U.S. Navy.

not under command—the state of a vessel that is disabled and not able to operate in accordance with the rules of the road.

nuclear reactor—a main component of a nuclear propulsion plant.

occulting navigation light—a flashing navigation light in which the duration of light is greater than the duration of darkness.

officers country—the living quarters of officers on board a Navy ship.

overheads—ceilings of spaces (compartments) on a vessel.

parallel ruler—a hinged two-part pair of straightedges designed to permit transfer of a parallel line from one place to another on a plot.

phase characteristics (of navigation lights)—patterns of flashes of navigation lights.

piloting—navigation near land using landmarks, aids to navigation, and depth soundings.

pitch (motion)—the upward and downward movement of the bow and stern of a vessel or aircraft around its athwartships axis.

port—nautical directional term for left; an observation window on a vessel; a town or city within a harbor or other navigable waterway where vessels are berthed.

prime meridian—the meridian passing through Greenwich, England.

prolonged whistle blast—a whistle blast of four to six seconds' duration by a ship's whistle.

propeller shaft—a shaft extending from the power plant of a vessel to its propellers, which delivers the rotational power to them.

protection—defensive features of a ship that help it survive an enemy attack.

pulpit—a platform enclosed by lifelines that overhangs the bowsprit of a powerboat or sailboat that provides room to handle the anchor and forward sail.

quarterdeck—the entrance/exit station of a ship.

rail (sailboat)—the deck edge of a sailboat.

range (visual)—two landmarks or navigation aids observed in line one behind the other.

rapid response team—an initial response team of designated damage control personnel that proceeds directly to the scene of fire or flooding both in port and under way.

reduction gears—a system of heavy gears in the propulsion system of a ship that acts like an automobile transmission to transition from the high speeds of an engine to lower propeller shaft speeds.

relative wind—the apparent direction and speed at which a wind is blowing relative to a vessel.

repair locker—a locker within each section of a ship containing a wide variety of damage control equipment for use by repair parties assigned to that section.

repair party—a group of specialists organized to control damage and make repairs throughout a ship during battle or shipboard emergency.

RHIB—rigid-hull inflatable boat.

rhumb lines—lines on the Earth's surface that cross all meridians at the same angle, appearing as straight lines on a Mercator map or chart.

rig (sailboat)—the arrangement of masts and sails on a sailboat.

rigging—a term used to describe all wires, ropes, and chains supporting masts, kingposts, or booms and cargo hooks. Standing rigging includes all lines that support masts and kingposts but do not move, and running rigging includes all movable lines that run through blocks.

right-of-way—the legal right and duty of a vessel to maintain course and speed as a stand-on vessel in certain approach situations under the nautical rules of the road.

RML—relative motion line on a maneuvering board plot.

roll (motion)—circular movement from side to side around the longitudinal axis of a vessel or aircraft.

rules of the road—the nautical rules by which ships maneuver to avoid collisions while under

way; traffic rules for vehicles on land.

running lights—lights required to be shown by all vessels when they are under way at night or in reduced visibility conditions by day.

running rigging—adjustable rigging for sails, masts, booms, and the like.

scale (of chart)—the ratio between the size of a feature shown on a chart and its actual size.

SCBA—self-contained breathing apparatus.

scope of chain—the length of an anchor chain, usually divided into fifteen-fathom segments called shots.

scuttle—a round access opening in a hatch; to intentionally sink a ship by flooding.

seamanship—skill in handling a boat or ship, or in doing those things related to the job of a seaman.

sea trials—a series of short cruises to check out the operation of a ship or submarine and its equipment following construction or overhaul.

seaworthiness—a ship's ability to operate in all kinds of weather, high winds, and heavy seas.

sextant—optical instrument primarily used to make altitude observations in celestial navigation.

shakedown cruise—a sea trial to verify seaworthiness, speed, endurance, and maneuverability under simulated operational conditions.

short stay—position of an anchor cable straight up and down, or nearly so, with the anchor barely holding the bottom.

shot (anchor chain)—a fifteen-fathom section of anchor chain, joined to the next shot by a detachable link.

SINS—ship's inertial navigation system.

six-minute rule—distance traveled in miles in six minutes multiplied by ten equals speed in knots.

solar time—time based on the relationship of the actual Sun to the Earth.

soundings—water or tankage depth measurements.

spaces (ship)—the compartments of a vessel.

speed log—device for measuring speed in or on water.

sponsor—a person chosen to christen a ship, traditionally female.

spontaneous combustion—ignition of a material caused by natural heat generated by rapid oxidation of its components.

spring lines—mooring lines that run at acute angles between a pier and a vessel, often in pairs, used to control a vessel's fore-and-aft movement alongside the pier.

stability—the manner in which a ship returns to an upright position after a roll.

stadimeter—an optical device used to determine the distance to an object of known height.

standard time—a system of fifteen-degree-wide sectors or zones of the Earth in which the same time is kept by all in each zone. Uses as a basis the relationship of the mean Sun with the central meridian of each zone. See also zone time.

standing rigging—heavy metal or wire supports for spars or masts, permanently installed.

stand-on vessel—the vessel obliged under the nautical rules of the road to maintain course and speed during an approach situation with another vessel while under way. See also give-way vessel.

starboard—nautical directional term for right.

stateroom—an officer's berthing compartment on board Navy and merchant vessels; a small crew or passenger berthing compartment on a merchant or cruise ship.

steam turbine—a main component of a steam propulsion plant consisting of several alternating rows of fixed and movable blades similar to those of a fan attached to a central rotating shaft.

steering signals—whistle signals required by international and inland rules for vessels maneuvering within sight of one another. Under international rules such signals are signals of action or execution, and under inland rules they are signals of intent.

stuffing tube—a watertight fitting in a bulkhead through which wires or cables are passed.

superstructure—all structures of a ship above the main deck.

three-minute rule—distance traveled in yards in three minutes divided by one hundred equals speed in knots. See also six-minute rule.

time signals—terrestrial or satellite-based broadcasts of signals of UTC time standards.

top-marks—conical or spherical daymarks fitted to the top of buoys to indicate their function or direction of safe water.

transom—the extreme back end of the stern of a powerboat.

trimaran—a triple-hulled vessel.

truck (ship)—the top of a mast.

true bearing—a bearing using true north as the reference.

true wind—true direction and speed at which a wind is blowing over the Earth's surface.

underway—the state of a vessel when it is not at anchor, not moored to a dock or buoy, and not aground.

UnRep—underway replenishment of a ship at sea.

variation angle—the angle between true and magnetic north.

vector diagram—a diagram on a maneuvering board consisting of vectors (arrows) to represent courses, relative motion lines, and speeds.

VertRep—vertical replenishment of a ship at sea by the use of helicopters.

visibility (of a navigation light)—the distance in nautical miles that a mariner can see the light.

voids (ship construction)—empty spaces within a vessel, usually near the bottom of the hull.

water-jet propulsion—a form of vessel propulsion utilizing a high-pressure water jet instead of traditional propellers for propulsion through the water.

waterline—the line on a vessel's hull to which it sinks in the water.

watertight integrity—the ability of a compartment on a vessel to withstand flooding.

windlass—a piece of deck machinery used to handle line, cable, or an anchor chain.

yaw—a lateral swinging movement of the bow and stern of a vessel or aircraft around its vertical axis.

zone time—time reckoned according to the relationship of the mean Sun with the central meridian of each fifteen-degree-wide time zone. See also standard time. ⚓

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